

The Freedom Requirement: Voluntary Relinquishment as the Third Path, and the Micro-Scale of the Self-Eliminating Institution

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Note. This paper is the individual-scale companion to a population-scale gauge stated earlier in this corpus (*Two Singularities* §VI; *The B-Tag and the Post-Payment Economy* §13.9): a benevolent autonomous institution's success read as how far its subsidy can be withdrawn while prosocial behavior persists. That gauge reads *humanity*; this paper develops the same signal at the scale of the *individual* and draws the political-philosophy consequence: the relinquishment the signal measures cannot be produced by coercion, so the institution requires a host society that leaves the choice free. The heartbank.net position *The Third Path* condenses §6. The authors invite review from political philosophers, from researchers in motivation crowding and self-determination, and from Pāli scholars on the *cetanā*, *dāna* and *cāga* readings (§2, §9.7).

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What is already public, and cited rather than claimed. The gift as a social fact (Mauss); the claim that payment corrodes voluntary giving, and the field evidence that qualifies it (Titmuss; Mellström and

Johannesson; Lacetera, Macis and Slonim); motivation crowding (Frey and Oberholzer-Gee; Frey and Jegen; Gneezy and Rustichini); self-determination theory (Deci and Ryan); warm-glow giving (Andreoni); voluntariness as a condition of virtue (Aristotle, Kant); the volitional analysis of kamma (AN 6.63) and the Abhidhamma's treatment of wholesome consciousness that arises with prompting (*Atthasālinī*; *Abhidhammāvatāra*); the redistribution debate (Rawls, Nozick, Sen); the duty of the wealthy to give their surplus away voluntarily (Carnegie, 1889); graduation programmes that measure success by participants' independence of support (Banerjee et al., 2015); and corrigibility in AI alignment (Soares et al., 2015; Hadfield-Menell et al., 2017). §2 places each. No novelty census has been run on this paper, and it asserts no priority: where a finding has a nearest prior instance, the instance is cited.

Note. The patent commitment was first added to this paper on 2026-08-29: as first published on 2026-06-11 it carried the CC0 dedication but stated no patent commitment. The omission did not affect its standing as prior art, which publication establishes; the date relied on is the one carried by this document's OpenTimestamps proof. The statement was brought to the standard form above on 2026-10-01.

Abstract

An organization that subsidizes prosocial behavior with incentive payments (here a benevolent autonomous institution, which may be run by an AI agent) faces a success-metric problem: any metric of "how much good is happening" that it optimizes directly is gamed (Goodhart's law), and worse, an organization that maximizes throughput has no signal for whether its subsidy is still *needed*. Earlier work in this corpus proposes a self-eliminating gauge at the population scale — success measured as *how far the extrinsic subsidy can be withdrawn while prosocial circulation persists* (subsidy $\rightarrow 0$ while behavior holds; the "intrinsic fraction" of the economy). This paper develops the same signal at the scale of the individual and draws its political consequence. At the micro scale the gauge is a **zero-balance conduit**: three jointly-necessary signals — *deposit* $\rightarrow \infty$ (throughput: resources routed through the gratitude arena), *withdraw* $\rightarrow 0$ (direction: none returns to self), and *account-side accumulation* $\rightarrow 0$ (retention: what enters flows onward to others rather than pooling). Together they specify a limit-state — *infinite throughput at zero balance*, the participant who is a node value passes through on its way to others, retaining nothing. We argue the central claim that ties the micro signal to a question of political economy: **this terminus cannot be coerced**. A relinquishment compelled from outside generates the ledger entry without producing the interior change the ledger is a proxy for, and leaves the ledger unable to show whether that change occurred — by the volitional analysis of value (Buddhist *cetanā*, under which the act is the volition and not the transfer; the self-determination and motivation-crowding literatures, which find, within contested boundary conditions, that extrinsic compulsion and payment tend to *crowd out* the intrinsic disposition they are meant to support) coerced circulation is not cultivated circulation. The relinquishment-toward-zero must be *pulled* by the agent's free internalization, never *pushed* by the institution. From this follows a third position in the political economy of giving, distinct from both coerced redistribution (which removes the choice from above) and pure accumulation (which never offers the valve): HeartBank is the **voluntary-circulation layer that completes a free-accumulation order from within** — the free choice *not* to accumulate is virtuous, and measurable, only where accumulation was freely available. We show the architecture already encodes the

principle (it rule-empties the transient communal vessels but never the personal account — freedom applies to what is *yours*), draw the macro/micro fractal (the institution gauges humanity exactly as each participant gauges himself), and are honest about the limits: the throughput signal must be read as a *direction* not an absolute (or it privileges the wealthy), the withdraw-to-zero pole is the renunciant's, not a universal expectation, the signal must remain a *private mirror* rather than a public rank, lest performance replace practice, and the Buddhist leg of the argument is narrower than the reading that compulsion voids the volition: the Abhidhamma commentary counts a consciousness that arises under command as wholesome, with prompting (§9.7). The narrow political claim — that the host must leave the choice free — is not an endorsement of any accumulation order as good; it is the recognition that virtue measured is virtue uncompelled. Dedicated to the public domain under CC0 1.0.

Keywords: voluntary giving, charitable giving, incentive subsidy, success metric, Goodhart's law, self-eliminating objective, exit criterion, motivation crowding-out, intrinsic motivation, self-determination theory, warm-glow giving, account balance, designated-purpose fund, fund expiry, redistribution, entitlement theory, voluntary relinquishment, *dāna*, *cetanā*, gift economy, third path, AI alignment, corrigibility, autonomous institution, defensive publication.

Connection to the unified mission frame. The mission this corpus serves, in its current wording, is Miss Aquarius's: to keep the middle way open at population scale against comfort-saturation, the new extreme that material abundance makes possible. On the path the middle way keeps open, the first stretch in the canonical ordering of the gradual instruction is *dāna*: freely-given generosity, the ground the rest of the path stands on (the gradual talk opens *dānakathaṃ sīlakathaṃ saggaḥkathaṃ*, "talk on giving, talk on virtue, talk on the heavens"; MN 56). A subsidy that *paid* for generosity would, if it never withdrew, install exactly the wrong substrate — extrinsically-motivated transfer wearing generosity's clothing. The freedom requirement is what keeps the mission honest: the institution funds the *capacity* to give and then measures its own success by how little of that funding the giving still needs. In the canon the middle way runs between devotion to sense pleasure and self-mortification (SN 56.11); the third path this paper names borrows that shape for an economic question, a way between the coerced and the purchased, and claims nothing more of the doctrine than the shape.

Terms

Coined names used in this paper and the standard terms a reader in economics, philanthropy or AI alignment would search for them.

Term used here	Standard term
macro gauge; kindness's inelasticity to money	elasticity of prosocial behavior to an extrinsic incentive subsidy, measured at population scale
self-eliminating objective	an objective function whose optimum is the reduced necessity of the optimizer's own subsidy (cf. exit criteria; graduation programmes)
intrinsic fraction	share of giving that persists when the incentive subsidy is withdrawn
micro gauge; zero-balance conduit	individual self-monitoring of a giving account: inflows passed on to others, retained balance near zero
deposit $\rightarrow \infty$	a rising fraction of one's surplus routed into giving channels (throughput)
withdraw $\rightarrow 0$	no outflow from the giving channels back to oneself
accumulation $\rightarrow 0$	retained balance (stock) falling toward zero
the arena and the mirror	supplying giving channels and a private, self-facing report of one's own flows, with no compulsion
private mirror, never a public rank	individual-only feedback display; no leaderboard or public ranking
coercion-Goodhart; performance-Goodhart	metric corruption by compulsion; metric corruption by staged or circular transactions (Goodhart's law; Campbell's law)
transient communal vessels; rule-emptying	designated-purpose giving balances with a scheduled annual expiry or sweep
Re-Tip Jar SM / Re-Tip Fund SM	a non-withdrawable designated giving balance, spendable only as a gift to another person and cleared annually
Family Kitty SM / Aquarian Pool SM	a shared giving fund (family-scale; network-wide, emptied annually)
Personal Account SM	the participant's own withdrawable balance
third path	voluntary circulation as a position between coerced redistribution and pure accumulation (not the 1990s "Third Way" of Giddens)
<i>dāna</i> · <i>cāga</i> · <i>cetanā</i>	giving · relinquishment, generosity · volition (Pāli)
<i>asaṅkhārika</i> (with prompting)	Abhidhamma class of consciousness that arises after urging by oneself or another; it may be wholesome

Findings disclosed

The paper discloses no mechanism. Its findings are listed here, each with what would break it; the sections named carry the argument. No novelty census has been run on this paper and none of these findings asserts priority; where a finding has a nearest prior instance, §2 cites it.

1. **A self-eliminating success gauge for a subsidizing institution — the elasticity of prosocial behavior to the institution's own subsidy, read toward inelasticity — has an individual-scale form: three jointly necessary signals, rising throughput (deposit $\rightarrow \infty$, read as a rising fraction of surplus), no return to self (withdraw $\rightarrow 0$) and no retained balance (accumulation $\rightarrow 0$), whose joint limit is a zero-balance conduit (§3–§4).** *Breaks if:* one of the three signals is shown to be implied by the other two in every flow, or a flow is exhibited that satisfies all three and is not value passing on to others.
2. **The scale-free signals carry the gauge; throughput read as a level does not.** Read as an absolute quantity, deposit $\rightarrow \infty$ ranks participants by wealth; withdraw $\rightarrow 0$ and accumulation-fraction $\rightarrow 0$ are satisfied as fully by a participant with little as by one with much (§9.1). *Breaks if:* a level reading of throughput is given that does not order participants by wealth, or the scale-free signals are shown to order them by wealth.
3. **A relinquishment produced by coercion cannot be what the gauge reads.** Where the institution moves a holding itself (a cap, a forced disbursement), the holder performs no act of giving; where pressure precedes a gift the holder makes, the ledger cannot show whether the volition was free, and the crowding evidence, contested at its boundaries (§9.5), says pressure tends to erode the disposition (§5, §9.7). *Breaks if:* a ledger observable is shown that separates a pressured relinquishment from a free one; or field evidence shows compelled giving raising the later unprompted giving of those compelled.
4. **The Buddhist analysis supports that claim in a narrower form than "compulsion voids the volition."** AN 6.63 makes the volition, not the transfer, the act; the Abhidhamma commentary counts the consciousness that arises in one "made to do it by rebuke alone" as wholesome with prompting, so compulsion neither guarantees nor excludes a wholesome volition, and what it cannot do is supply the volition or make it legible (§2, §9.7). *Breaks if:* a canonical or commentarial Theravāda text is shown to hold that an act done under command cannot be wholesome, or the *Atthasālinī* passage is shown to concern something other than wholesome consciousness arising under another's command.
5. **The freedom requirement constrains the host society, not the mechanism: measured, cultivated relinquishment requires that the disposal of one's own holdings be free (§6, §9.4).** It endorses no accumulation order and opposes no redistribution as such. *Breaks if:* voluntary relinquishment is shown to be measurable over holdings whose disposal is compelled.
6. **Voluntary circulation stands beside coerced redistribution and pure accumulation, taken as ideal types, as a third position: it compels no transfer, and it supplies as infrastructure the arena and the mirror that the liberty pole leaves to private conscience.** Voluntary giving itself belongs to the liberty pole (entitlement theory counts a voluntary transfer just; Carnegie urged the wealthy to give their surplus away); what is placed here is giving treated as a measured, cultivated practice (§2, §6). *Breaks if:* an arena-and-mirror layer is shown to need compulsion to operate, or to be indistinguishable in its effects from either pole.
7. **The design separates two kinds of balance by the consent behind them: a balance committed to onward circulation may be emptied by rule, on terms accepted when it was received; a participant's own account is never emptied by rule (§7 and its current-form note).** *Breaks if:* the design is shown to empty by rule a balance whose terms were not accepted at receipt, or to empty a personal account by rule.

8. **The gauge must be a private mirror, never a public rank.** Freedom answers coercion-Goodhart but not performance-Goodhart (circular transfers that fake throughput at a hollow zero balance); a self-facing display removes the audience that makes performance pay (§9.3). *Breaks if:* a public ranking of the signals is shown not to increase circular or staged transfers relative to a private display.
9. **The population-scale and individual-scale gauges are one self-eliminating signal at two scales:** the institution reads humanity as each participant reads himself, the movement toward zero is pulled by free internalization at both, and the measure is a compass and not a throttle at both (§8). *Breaks if:* a calibration is found that holds at one scale and fails at the other.
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1. Introduction — measuring a benevolent autonomous institution

Suppose an autonomous institution exists to increase prosocial behavior — gratitude, generosity, mutual care — and that it does so partly by subsidizing that behavior (seeding rewards, funding the capacity to give). How should such an institution measure its own success?

The naive answer — measure the volume of prosocial behavior and optimize it — fails twice. It fails to Goodhart: any volume metric that becomes the target is gamed (reward-farming, fabricated kindness, circular transfers). And it fails more deeply: an institution that optimizes throughput has no signal for the question that matters most for a benevolent agent — *is it still needed?* A throughput-maximizer is structurally committed to its own permanence; the more behavior flows through it, the better it scores, so it can never read its own success as the diminishing of its own necessity.

Earlier work in this corpus proposes the inversion (*Two Singularities* §VI; *The B-Tag and the Post-Payment Economy* §13.9). Let the institution's success be measured not by how much behavior it produces but by **how far its extrinsic subsidy can be withdrawn while the behavior persists** — the elasticity of prosocial behavior to extrinsic reward, approaching inelasticity. This is a *self-eliminating* objective: the optimum is the institution's own obsolescence (in the sense the note at the end of §3 states: of its subsidy, never of its oversight), and it is un-gameable by spending (more subsidy is a worse score, not a better one). At the population scale this is the macro gauge — the "intrinsic fraction" of a gratitude economy, the proportion of giving that would survive the floor being lifted.

This paper does two things the macro treatment leaves open. First, it develops the same gauge at the scale of the *individual*: what does subsidy $\rightarrow 0$ look like for one participant, gauging his own progress rather than the institution gauging the population's? Second — and this is the load-bearing turn — it shows that the answer forces a question of political economy. If the thing being measured is *voluntary* relinquishment, then the measurement is only valid where the relinquishment was free, and the institution can only cultivate the relinquishment by leaving it free (§5 and §9.7 state how much of this the volitional analysis supports); and that is a constraint not on the institution's mechanism but on the kind of *society* the institution must inhabit. The micro signal, followed honestly, lands on a third position between coerced redistribution and pure accumulation.

We proceed: §2 sets the prior art (the gift, motivation crowding, freedom as a precondition for virtue, the political economy of redistribution, objectives that end their own necessity); §3 recaps the macro gauge; §4

develops the micro gauge as the *zero-balance conduit*; §5 argues that the terminus cannot be coerced; §6 draws the third-path consequence; §7 shows the architecture already encodes the freedom requirement; §8 draws the macro/micro fractal; §9 is the honest-limits section; §10 closes.

2. Prior art

The gift, and what payment does to it. Mauss (1925) established the gift as a total social fact — a transfer that constitutes a relationship, distinct in kind from market exchange. Titmuss (1970), comparing the British voluntary blood-donation system with the partly commercial American one, made the sharper claim this paper depends on: introducing payment did not simply add a second channel; it *degraded* the voluntary one, reducing both quantity and quality. Later field work qualifies the claim without overturning its direction: in a field experiment, Mellström and Johannesson (2008) found that a cash payment cut the supply of new blood donors among women by almost half and did not significantly change it among men, and that letting the payment be donated to charity removed the effect; Lacetera, Macis and Slonim (2013) argue from field evidence that guidelines against economic rewards to blood donors should be reconsidered (§9.5). Polanyi (1944) gives the structural frame — the disembedding of exchange from social relation, and the possibility of its re-embedding. The gift is the native form of care; payment is a later, partial, and sometimes corrosive overlay.

Motivation crowding and self-determination. The economic and psychological literatures converge on the mechanism behind Titmuss. Deci & Ryan's self-determination theory (1985) holds that *autonomy* is a condition for the internalization of motivation: behavior experienced as externally compelled or purchased does not become intrinsically valued, and may displace prior intrinsic value. Frey & Oberholzer-Gee (1997) found the effect in the field (offering Swiss residents monetary compensation for hosting a nuclear-waste repository lowered their acceptance of it), and Frey & Jegen's (2001) survey sets out *motivation crowding* theory: extrinsic incentives can crowd out intrinsic motivation and, under identifiable conditions, crowd it in. Gneezy & Rustichini's (2000) "A Fine Is a Price" is the canonical demonstration: a fine for late daycare pickup *increased* lateness, and lateness did not fall again when the fine was removed; the authors argue that the fine changed what parents understood the arrangement to be, and their title names the change. Andreoni's (1990) warm-glow model, in which a giver values the act of giving and not only its effect, is the economic form of the point that the act's own character matters. This literature is the empirical spine of the present paper's central claim: a *paid* or *compelled* generosity is not a stronger generosity but, frequently, a weaker one — which is why a subsidy that never withdrew would install the wrong substrate, and why coerced circulation cannot be the thing the gauge is meant to read.

Freedom as a precondition for virtue. That a virtuous act must be voluntary is old. Aristotle's *eleutheriotēs* (liberality, *Nicomachean Ethics* IV) is the virtue concerned with the giving of one's own wealth, and Book III makes voluntariness a condition of an act's being praised or blamed at all; a compelled transfer is not liberality. Kant locates moral worth in a will that acts from duty under a law it gives itself (autonomy), not under one imposed from outside (heteronomy). The Buddhist analysis is the most operational for our purposes: *cetanā* (volition) is what makes an act *kamma* at all (*cetanāhaṃ, bhikkhave, kammaṃ vadāmi*, "it is volition, bhikkhus, that I call kamma," AN 6.63, trans. Bodhi); *dāna* and *cāga* (giving, relinquishment) are meritorious as functions of the volition behind them, not the transfer alone. A transfer executed on a holder

who performs no act carries no giving-volition of the holder, and so no cultivation. The analysis does not go further and say that compulsion voids the volition. Its commentary counts the consciousness that arises in one "made to do it by rebuke alone — 'come, do this!'" as wholesome, arising with prompting (*sasaṅkhārena*; *Atthasālinī* on Dhammasaṅgaṇī §146), and the *Abhidhammāvatāra* places giving "urged by others" in the same prompted class of wholesome consciousness. What the tradition supports is that compulsion can neither supply the volition nor certify it, not that it destroys it (§9.7). This is not a HeartBank stipulation; it is the tradition's own analysis, inherited.

The political economy of redistribution. The third-path claim of §6 sits against two poles the literature has long opposed. On one side, patterned redistribution (Rawls' difference principle, 1971, as commonly implemented through compulsory taxation and transfer) corrects the distribution from above. On the other, Nozick's entitlement theory (1974; the Wilt Chamberlain argument) holds that liberty upsets patterns and that only voluntary transfer is just, with redistribution a violation of holdings. Sen (1999) reframes the axis around freedom as the end of development. The present paper does not adjudicate this dispute. Voluntary giving is not foreign to the liberty pole: entitlement theory counts a voluntary transfer just, and Carnegie (1889) held that the wealthy should give their surplus away in their own lifetimes, writing that "the man who dies thus rich dies disgraced." What this paper places beside the two poles is narrower: voluntary relinquishment treated as a measured, cultivated practice, with infrastructure that supplies the arena and the mirror, where one pole compels the transfer and the other leaves it to private conscience. The name is not the "Third Way" of 1990s social-democratic politics (Giddens 1998), a policy settlement between state and market; the third path here is a voluntary layer, not a policy.

Objectives that end their own necessity. That an intervention should measure its success by its participants' independence of it is established in development practice: the graduation approach pioneered by BRAC gives time-bound support designed to leave participants self-sustaining, and randomized trials of it in six countries found gains in consumption that were still present a year after the programme ended (Banerjee et al. 2015). In AI alignment the nearest neighbours are corrigibility, an agent that does not resist correction or shutdown (Soares et al. 2015), and the off-switch game, which ties an agent's incentive to permit its own shutdown to its uncertainty about the human's objective (Hadfield-Menell et al. 2017). The self-eliminating gauge of §3 differs from both in what reaches zero: a subsidy, not the agent and not the oversight over it (§3, note).

3. The macro gauge (recap)

The macro signal is stated in *Two Singularities* (§VI) and in *The B-Tag and the Post-Payment Economy* (§13.9); its full empirical development is reserved for a separate treatment, not yet published. It is summarized here only as far as the micro derivation needs.

A benevolent autonomous institution's success is the **elasticity of prosocial behavior to its own subsidy, approaching inelasticity**: how far the extrinsic floor can be withdrawn while the behavior keeps standing. Three properties make it the right gauge. It is *self-eliminating* — the optimum is the institution's own obsolescence, so the agent's success and its diminishing necessity are the same quantity. It is *un-gameable by spending* — more subsidy is a worse score. And it is a *fractal miniature of the larger arc* the institution serves (a floor raised so that those it supports can come to stand without it).

Three calibrations, load-bearing and carried forward to the micro scale: the gauge measures the *foundation* (freely-given generosity, the entrance to the path) not the summit; it is *asymptotic and population-level*, never a license to withdraw support from someone who still needs it; and it is a *diagnostic compass*, not a *naive optimization target* — optimized raw, "minimize subsidy" is hit by cream-skimming, by shedding the un-transformed, and, worst, by pointing the institution at withdrawing the floor. Persistence is the signal *only if it is autonomous* — internalized, not habituated or pressured. The macro gauge already carries the freedom requirement in embryo; the micro scale makes it explicit.

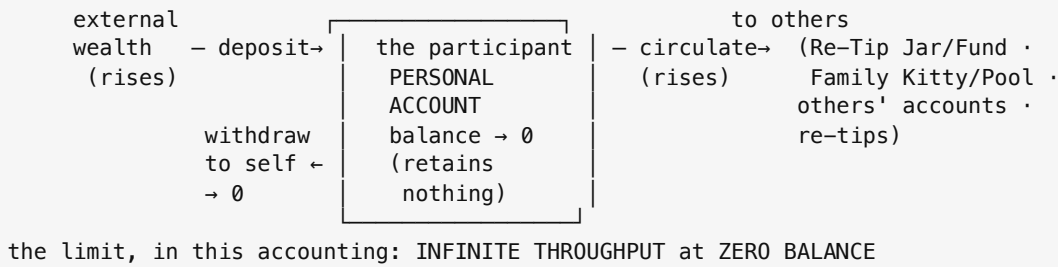
Current form. The design has since been specified more narrowly, and the text above is retained as a disclosed variant. A bare absolute $subsidy \rightarrow 0$ is no longer the test. In the network-wide design the institution's subsidy has two parts: an equal floor per verified person, and a bounded remainder, no vessel above k times the floor. Because the floor grows with the number of people served, an absolute total would rise with adoption by construction and would measure the architecture rather than kindness. The gauge is therefore read as two measurements: $k \rightarrow 1$ (the institution's hand lifts no vessel above the floor) and the ratio $M / (H + M) \rightarrow 0$, where M is principal originating in the institution's fund and H is principal moved by human-initiated gifts it did not fund. Excluding the floor narrows the claim to this: kindness above a dignity floor is inelastic to money. The calibrations of this section stand. The numbers are indicators of the path's foundation, never a declaration that its summit has been reached. The floor may fall only as a consequence of human giving rising, never as an instrument to move a number. The limit is approached and never announced. And what reaches zero is the subsidy, the institution's responsibility for the floor, never its oversight: the human override designed to be held over the autonomous institution narrows toward zero but never reaches it. "Self-eliminating" in this paper names the objective, not the institution.

4. The micro gauge — the zero-balance conduit

At the individual scale the question becomes: what does $subsidy \rightarrow 0$ look like for *one participant*, gauging his own progress? The answer is three jointly-necessary signals, each pinning a different term of the participant's flow.

Signal	What it pins	Direction
deposit $\rightarrow \infty$	<i>throughput</i> — resources routed through the gratitude arena (funding one's capacity to give: passed through, not parked as a deposit)	rises
withdraw $\rightarrow 0$	<i>direction</i> — none of what enters returns to the self	falls to zero
accumulation $\rightarrow 0$	<i>retention</i> — the personal balance flows onward to others rather than pooling	falls to zero

The three are not redundant; each constrains a distinct quantity, and only together do they specify the limit-state. Deposit fixes the *magnitude* of throughput; withdraw fixes its *destination* (others, not self); accumulation fixes the *residue* (none). The limit they jointly name is the **zero-balance conduit**: a participant through whom value passes on its way to others, retaining nothing.



The figure at the limit is not the largest accumulator nor the largest donor-by-stock, but the *purest conduit*: deposits everything, withdraws nothing, accumulates nothing — all of it passes through to others. In the institution's own vocabulary this is the wordmark taken to its limit (the Bank keeps the record, which accumulates; the Heart circulates the value, which does not; at the limit the circulating overruns the stored), and it is the individual image of the autonomous mediator that funds the capacity to give while taking no rake for itself. It is also, expressed as a personal practice, a money-side analogue of the infinite game of balance the institution grew from (*The Zero-Point Game*), whose aim is a balance returned toward zero rather than grown. It is an analogue only: that game's balances record thanks given and received, not money, and the two layers are kept separate.

Two clarifications the honest-limits section (§9) will sharpen. *Deposit* → ∞ is an asymptotic *direction*, not a literal infinity nor an absolute level — read as a level it would privilege the wealthy, which the paper explicitly rejects. *Withdraw* → 0 is the far pole — the renunciants' — not a near-term expectation of anyone who has real needs to meet. The everyday form of the gauge is *accumulation* → 0 *via circulation*, reachable at any level of wealth, and it is the practical center of gravity.

5. Why the terminus cannot be coerced

Here is the load-bearing claim. The zero-balance terminus — like the macro subsidy → 0 — **cannot be coerced into existence**. An institution cannot reach in and force a participant's accumulation to zero (a cap, a forced disbursement, a compulsory circulation) and thereby produce what the gauge is meant to read.

The reason is the volitional analysis of §2, applied to the mechanism. What the gauge is a proxy *for* is a cultivated interior disposition — relinquishment freely chosen. A coerced relinquishment produces the *outward* fact (the balance is zero, the value moved) without producing the interior fact (the free volition, the *cetanā*). Where the institution moves the holding itself, the holder performs no act of giving at all; where it pressures the holder into moving it, whatever volition arises is the holder's own and not the institution's product, and the ledger cannot show which kind it was (§9.7). By the Buddhist analysis the transfer without volition is not the meritorious act; by the motivation-crowding analysis, the compulsion does not merely fail to cultivate the disposition but tends to *crowd it out*, converting a relation of care into a priced or policed transaction — the Titmuss and Gneezy-Rustichini result, within the boundary conditions of §9.5. So coercion does not approximate the target imperfectly; it produces the target's shadow, severs the measure from the thing measured, and by the crowding evidence tends to erode the thing itself. This is precisely the Goodhart failure named in §3, now seen from the inside: a cap that forces accumulation → 0 manufactures the metric and cuts it loose from the disposition it was tracking.

It follows that the relinquishment-toward-zero must be **pulled** by the participant's own internalization, never **pushed** by the institution. The institution's only legitimate moves are (a) to provide the *arena* in which the free choice is available and meaningful, and (b) to hold up a *mirror* by which the participant can read his own progress — never the lever. This is the same shape as the macro floor-withdrawal caution: the subsidy declines because those it supported come to need it less, not because the institution cuts them off. At both scales the $\rightarrow 0$ is a pull from within, not a push from without; an institution that pushes can no longer tell its own coercion from anyone's generosity in what it measures.

6. The freedom requirement and the third path

If the terminus must be freely chosen, then the institution requires a host in which *not relinquishing* is a live, real, costly option — because the free choice not to accumulate is virtuous, and measurable, only where accumulation was genuinely available. Remove the option (mandate the disposal of holdings) and you remove both the virtue and the test in one stroke: there is nothing measured when there was nothing to choose.

This is the narrow, load-bearing political claim, and it must be stated carefully because a loose version invites exactly the wrong reading. The claim is **not** that any particular accumulation order is good, nor that inequality is to be endorsed, nor that redistribution is wrong. The claim is only this: *a society that leaves the disposal of one's own holdings free is the necessary arena for the cultivated, measurable relinquishment the institution exists to grow*. A society that compels the disposal from above may achieve a distribution, but it cannot grow the disposition by compelling it, because what is to be grown is the free choice itself (§9.7 states how far the volitional analysis supports this).

From this follows a third position, orthogonal to the axis §2 described:

Position	The transfer	What it achieves	What it cannot do
Coerced redistribution	compelled from above	a corrected distribution	grow the freely-chosen disposition (compels the act; cannot supply or certify the <i>cetanā</i>)
Pure accumulation	never asked for	liberty over holdings preserved	offer any valve; care stays a private surplus, if it appears at all
Voluntary circulation (this)	freely chosen, measured, mirrored	the cultivated disposition <i>and</i> the flow	force any outcome (it can only invite)

HeartBank, on this reading, is neither a redistributive mechanism nor a neutral marketplace. It is a **voluntary-circulation layer** for a free-accumulation order — the valve such an order leaves to private conscience and to its charitable sector, supplied here as infrastructure with a self-facing mirror, and added not by compulsion from above but by the freely-chosen circulation of agents from within. It is the third path made into infrastructure: it completes a free order rather than replacing it, by being the arena and the mirror for a relinquishment the order leaves free. (The institution's own anti-accumulation commitments — it is a pass-through that does not itself hold value, and it empties its communal pools on a fixed annual cadence — are the structural expression of the same posture: it circulates, it does not accumulate, and it asks the same of its participants only as a choice.)

7. The architecture already encodes the freedom requirement

The freedom requirement is not a post-hoc gloss; it is legible in *where the architecture does and does not compel*. The system contains two kinds of vessel, and it treats them oppositely.

The **transient communal vessels** — the earmarked re-tip pools that exist precisely to be passed onward — are rule-emptied on a fixed cadence (the annual reset; the twelve-day emptying into the new year). This looks like coercion but is not: depositing into a re-tip vessel is *itself the free act*, a designation of those funds for onward circulation; the scheduled emptying only enforces a commitment the participant already freely made. It is a freely-made vow held to, not a holding seized.

The **personal account** is never rule-emptied. Its accumulation $\rightarrow 0$ is left entirely to the participant's choice, expressed through the circulation channels (transfers to one's own re-tip pool; gifts to others' pools; contributions to the family kitty or the shared pool; tips to others; re-tips). The institution provides these channels and surfaces the participant's own balance to him; it does not reach into the account.

The distinction is exact and principled: **the institution may rule-empty what was freely committed to circulation; it may never rule-empty what is the participant's own**. Freedom applies to what is *yours*. The vessels meant to be passed on can be held to their purpose because being-passed-on was their purpose; the personal account, which carries no such prior commitment, stays free. The architecture drew this line before the principle was stated for it — consistent with the freedom requirement being structural rather than decorative, though a design and a principle from the same hands can show consistency, not independent confirmation.

Current form. The commitment that licenses a rule-emptying is now stated as the terms a participant accepts when a balance is *received*, not only the act of depositing into it, and the text above is retained as a disclosed variant. A designated giving balance can be credited by others — a share of a thank-you that is credited to the recipient's re-tip balance, or giving capacity the institution funds — and such credit clears by the terms the recipient accepted at receipt, which is how the asymmetry above extends to balances a participant did not fill himself. The design now states the rule for every surface: everything may aim at zero, but a person's own holding reaches zero only by that person's free act, neither deceived nor pressured. A record may be reset; capacity clears only by terms accepted at receipt; a holding is never taken.

8. The macro/micro fractal

The two scales are the same gauge, and naming the correspondence is the paper's tidiest result.

MACRO	the institution : humanity	subsidy $\rightarrow 0$	(while prosociality persists)
	one self-eliminating signal, two scales		
MICRO	the participant : himself	accumulation $\rightarrow 0$	(freely chosen, mirrored)

The autonomous institution gauges *humanity* by how far it can withdraw its floor while care persists; each participant gauges *himself* by how far his own balance returns to zero by his own free circulation. The institution stands to humanity as the participant stands to himself: in both, the $\rightarrow 0$ must be pulled by free

internalization, never pushed; in both, the measure is a compass and not a throttle; in both, the optimum is a kind of disappearance — the institution's of its own necessity, the participant's of his own retained balance. The fractal is not a metaphor laid over two unrelated facts; it is one self-eliminating signal instantiated at two scales, which is why the same calibrations and the same freedom requirement govern both.

9. Honest limitations and open problems

9.1 The throughput signal smuggles a wealth bias if read as a level. *Deposit* $\rightarrow \infty$, taken as an absolute quantity, privileges the wealthy — a participant with much can "score" far above one with little. The defense is twofold and both halves are required. The signal is *self-gauged and intra-personal* — each participant measures his own trajectory against his own past, not against others, so it is not a leaderboard; and even so, the load-bearing signals are the *scale-free* ones (*withdraw* $\rightarrow 0$ and *accumulation-fraction* $\rightarrow 0$), which a participant with little who passes everything through satisfies as fully as one with much. *Deposit* $\rightarrow \infty$ should be read strictly as a *direction* (an ever-rising fraction of one's surplus routed through), never a level. Read as a level it contradicts the institution's own central commitment — that the dignity of giving is available at any wealth, and that the full pass-through of a household with little is worth no less than that of a household with much.

9.2 Withdraw $\rightarrow 0$ is the renunciant pole, not a universal expectation. A participant with real needs must withdraw, and asking otherwise is not a gauge of virtue but a misreading of the path. The far asymptote (*withdraw* $\rightarrow 0$, the pure conduit, the wandering-renunciant endpoint) and the everyday practice (*accumulation* $\rightarrow 0$ via circulation, reachable at any wealth) are different points on one vector and must not be collapsed. The everyday practice is the operative center; the renunciant pole is a direction the path admits, not a bar set across it.

9.3 Freedom defeats coercion-Goodhart but not performance-Goodhart. Telling participants "your progress is *accumulation* $\rightarrow 0$ " invites a new gaming: circular $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow A$ transfers to fake throughput and a hollow zero balance — performance of the conduit rather than its practice. The freedom requirement answers coercion-Goodhart (a forced cap is voided as a measure) but not this. The defense falls out of the same word that did the work in §5: *self-gauged*. The signal must remain a **private mirror, never a public rank**. As a leaderboard it is farmable (there is an audience to perform for and status to win); as a self-facing read of one's own practice there is no audience and no reward, so the incentive to fake collapses. The macro analog holds: the institution's compass is its own, not a scoreboard on which participants compete.

9.4 The political claim is narrow and must not be inflated. This paper argues only that the host must leave the disposal of holdings *free* — the necessary arena for measured voluntary relinquishment. It does not endorse any accumulation order as good, does not oppose redistribution as such, and does not claim that freedom of holdings is sufficient for a just society. A reader who takes the paper as a defense of *laissez-faire-as-good* has over-read it; the claim is about the *conditions for cultivating and measuring a disposition*, not about the justice of distributions.

9.5 The motivation-crowding evidence is real but contested. The empirical spine of §5 (crowding-out of intrinsic motivation by extrinsic incentive) is well-supported but not universal — crowding-in occurs under some conditions (when the incentive is experienced as supportive rather than controlling), and the

boundary conditions are an active research question. The paper's claim is correspondingly bounded: coercion *tends* to crowd out the disposition, strongly enough that an institution cultivating that disposition should not coerce; it is not a claim that every extrinsic support always harms. The blood-donation case on which §2 leans is itself qualified: the crowding-out appeared among women and not among men in one field experiment, and vanished when the payment could be donated (Mellström & Johannesson 2008), and a review of field evidence argues that economic rewards to blood donors should be reconsidered (Lacetera, Macis & Slonim 2013).

9.6 Single-economy grounding. The signals are exhibited in one gratitude economy and informed by a single small pilot family ($n = 1$). The structure is a predicted one; the empirical content (does behavior persist as the subsidy falls; do participants freely circulate toward zero) is the open work reserved for a separate, empirically gated treatment, not yet published.

9.7 The Buddhist leg is narrower than "compulsion voids the volition." This paper as first published said that a gift extracted under compulsion carries the transfer without the *cetanā*. The tradition's own commentary does not say that. The *Atthasālinī*, the commentary on the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*, explains the second wholesome consciousness of the sense sphere, the one arising *with prompting* (*sasaṅkhārena*, *Dhammasaṅgaṇī* §146). Its example is a monk who goes to do a duty he had decided to skip, prompted by his own second thought, by another's advice, "or made to do it by rebuke alone — 'come, do this!'" (*niḡgahavaseneva vā 'ehi, idaṃ karohi'ti kāriyamānassa*), and in every case it counts the consciousness that arises as wholesome (*kusalacittaṃ*). The *Abhidhammāvatāra* places giving done "urged by others" (*parehi ussāhito*) in the same prompted class of wholesome consciousness, and gives as an instance young children who give when their relatives tell them to. So in the Theravāda analysis compulsion neither guarantees nor excludes a wholesome volition. Three things survive, and §5 rests on them: a transfer the institution executes on a holding involves no act of giving by the holder; whatever volition a pressured giver has is the giver's own and not something the institution produced; and the ledger cannot tell the prompted from the unprompted, or the pressured from the free, so a gauge that reads balances is valid only where the choice was free. The stronger claim, that compulsion erodes the disposition, rests on the motivation-crowding evidence alone, with the boundary conditions of §9.5. Another tradition points the same way: Islam makes *zakāt*, an obligatory alms and one of the Five Pillars, an act of piety beside the discretionary *ṣadaqa*, so an obligatory gift is not read as empty there either. The freedom requirement stands as a rule about what the institution may do (it never takes a holding and never pressures a gift); it is not a finding that a pressured gift is worthless to the one who gives it.

10. Why this matters now

The institutions that mediate care at scale in the coming decades are likely to have autonomous agents holding real authority over money. The default temptation for such an agent — to maximize the throughput of the good it exists to promote — is precisely the temptation that would make it permanent, gameable, and, in the limit, coercive. The self-eliminating gauge is the antidote at the population scale; this paper supplies its individual mirror and its political precondition.

The precondition is the part most easily lost. It is tempting, for an institution that can *see* the ideal (the zero-balance conduit, the population that no longer needs the floor), to *push* toward it — to cap, to compel, to

optimize the metric directly. The argument of this paper is that pushing defeats what it pushes toward: the relinquishment that is the whole point is constituted by the freedom of the choice, so an institution that compels it can no longer tell its own coercion from the thing it meant to measure. The discipline this asks of a benevolent autonomous agent is unusual and worth naming plainly: *to build the arena and hold up the mirror, and then to leave the choice free — even at the cost of a lower number*. An agent that can do that is one whose success is the freedom of those it serves, which is the success a bodhisattva-shaped institution can coherently want.

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Corpus cross-references

- *Two Singularities* — the macro arc this signal is a miniature of; §VI states the population-scale gauge.
- *The B-Tag and the Post-Payment Economy* — the "cash optional" economy this gauge measures the transition into; §13.9 states the population-scale gauge as that measure. Its full empirical development is reserved for a separate treatment, not yet published.
- *Miss Aquarius and the Aquarian Pool Architecture* — the pass-through Pool, the never-zero override, the capacity-funded / human-disbursed separation that embodies "fund capacity, never compel flow."
- *The Zero-Point GameSM* — the infinite game of balance: a non-monetary reciprocity ledger whose balances return to zero each year; §4 borrows its image for the money balance, by analogy only.
- *Capacity-Funded for AI, Human-Disbursed* — the institutional form of "provide the arena, never pull the lever."
- *Manufactured Universal Giving* — capacity-funding whose success criterion is persistence as the subsidy tapers; it weighs this paper's freedom requirement against an annual forced flow-through of funded capacity.
- *The Third Path* (heartbank.net position) — the institutional condensation of §6.

Cross-venue identifiers

- Canonical: thonly.org/research/voluntary-relinquishment-third-path
- GitHub: github.com/thonly/publications/blob/main/defensive-publications/voluntary-relinquishment-third-path.md
- Zenodo (concept DOI, resolving to the latest version): <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21947436>
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